Pei Zhang

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Education

2019/09 - 2025/05 **Ph.D. in Mathematical Statistics, University of Maryland, College Park** (UMD)
Dissertation title: *Mixed Modeling Approaches for Characterizing Genetic Effects and Heritability Metrics in Longitudinal Phenotypes* (NIH Outstanding Graduate Research)
Primary Advisors: *Drs. Paul S. Albert (NIH Biostatistics) and Doron Levy (UMD Applied Mathematics)*
Co-advisors: *Drs. Jianxin Shi (NIH Biostatistics) and Hyokyoung G. Hong (NIH Biostatistics)*

2014/09 - 2016/06 **M.S. in Mathematics, University of Science and Technology of China** (USTC)
Dissertation title: *Ekeland Index Theory for Periodic Solutions and Symmetric Periodic Solutions of Convex Hamiltonian Systems*
Advisor: *Dr. Xinan Ma*
Co-advisor: *Dr. Hui Liu*

2010/09 - 2014/06 **B.S. in Mathematics and Applied Mathematics (Teacher Education Program), Nanjing Normal University** (NNU)
Dissertation title: *Some Problems in Hamiltonian Systems* (NNU Outstanding Graduation Thesis)
Advisor: *Dr. Yujun Dong*

2009/09 - 2010/06 **Undergraduate in Computer Science, NNU**

Employment History

2025/05 - present **Postdoctoral Fellow (Mentored by Drs. Paul S. Albert and Jianxin Shi)**
Biostatistics Branch (BB), Division of Cancer Epidemiology & Genetics (DCEG)
National Cancer Institute (NCI), National Institutes of Health (NIH)

2021/09 - 2025/05 **Predoctoral Fellow (Mentored by Drs. Paul S. Albert and Jianxin Shi, and Hyokyoung G. Hong)**
BB, DCEG
NCI, NIH

2019/08 - 2021/08 **Teaching Assistant**
Department of Mathematics, UMD

2016/08 - 2017/04 **Mathematics Teacher**
NO.1 Middle School Affiliated to Central China Normal University, Wuhan, China

Employment History (continued)

2014/09 - 2016/06 **Teaching Assistant**
Department of Mathematics, USTC

Research Interests

- **Longitudinal and correlated data methodology**, with emphasis on repeated-measures analysis, biomarker studies, and complex dependent data structures.
- **Statistical and computational methods in genetics and genomics** for analyzing electronic health records (EHR), real-world data (RWD), and large-scale population studies (e.g., the Prostate, Lung, Colorectal, and Ovarian (PLCO) Cancer Screening Trial), with applications to prostate cancer risk stratification, early detection, and prediction.
- **Statistical and machine learning approaches in epidemiology**, including machine learning and deep learning for cancer genetic epidemiology, nutritional epidemiology, and metabolomics.

Publications

* corresponding author † co-first / equal contribution ‡ alphabetical order

Methodological / Statistical Papers

1. **Zhang, Pei**, X. Wang, Shi, Jianxin*, and Albert, Paul S.*, "Estimating the heritability of longitudinal rate-of-change: Genetic insights into PSA velocity in prostate cancer-free individuals," *Biostatistics*, 2026, *Biostatistics* (In Press), preprint on arXiv [arXiv].
2. **Zhang, Pei**, Albert, Paul S.*, and Hong, Hyokyoung G.*, "Mixed modeling approach for characterizing the genetic effects in a longitudinal phenotype," *Annals of Applied Statistics*, vol. 19, no. 3, pp. 2070–2087, 2025, [PDF].

Collaborative / Applied Papers

1. H. Fan, H. Zhao, **Zhang, Pei**, P. Yu, Y. Ji, G. Chen, H. Jin, Y. Liu, J. Liu, Z.-S. Chen, Lyu, Aiping*, Liang, Xinmiao*, and Chen, Yang*, "Homoisoflavanone delays colorectal cancer progression via DNA damage-induced mitochondrial apoptosis and parthanatos-like cell death," *Advanced Science*, e11406, 2026, [PDF].
2. H. Fan, H. Zhao, L. Gao, Y. Dong, **Zhang, Pei**, P. Yu, Y. Ji, Z.-S. Chen, X. Liang, and Chen, Yang*, "CCN1 enhances tumor immunosuppression through collagen-mediated chemokine secretion in pancreatic cancer," *Advanced Science*, e2500589, 2025, [PDF].
3. Loftfield, Erikka†*, **Zhang, Pei**†, C. P. O'Connell, L. L. Kahle, K. Herrick, L. Abar, N. Khandpur, E. M. Steele, and H. G. Hong, "Performance of a food frequency questionnaire for estimating ultraprocessed food intake according to the NOVA classification system in the United States NIH-AARP diet and health study," *Journal of Nutrition*, vol. 155, no. 7, pp. 2376–2384, 2025, [PDF].
4. Wu, Yetian†, **Zhang, Pei**†, H. Fan, C. Zhang, P. Yu, X. Liang, and Chen, Yang*, "GPR35 acts a dual role and therapeutic target in inflammation," *Frontiers in Immunology*, vol. 14, no. 1254446, 2023, [PDF].

Preprints / Under Review

1. Lim, Jungeun*, **Zhang, Pei**, J. Rhee, M. C. Playdon, A. J. Cross, R. Stolzenberg-Solomon, V. L. Roger, M. P. Purdue, Albanes, Demetrius*, Hong, Hyokyoung G.*, and Wong, Jason Y. Y.*, "Metabolomic profile score for predicting serum per- and polyfluoroalkyl substance (PFAS) levels: A novel application of machine learning to enhance detection of environmental pollutants," Under review at *International Journal of Hygiene and Environmental Health*, 2026.

PhD Thesis

1. **Zhang, Pei**, "Mixed modeling approaches for characterizing genetic effects and heritability metrics in longitudinal phenotypes," [PDF], Ph.D. dissertation, University of Maryland, College Park, 2025.

Honors

2026	NCI Early K99/R00 Grant Application — Rated as "Competitive, Not Discussed"
	National Science Foundation (NSF) Travel Support Award, USA
	Institute of Mathematical Statistics (IMS) New Researcher Travel Award, USA
2025 & 2026	NIH Postdoctoral Fellowship (twice)
2025	NCI-DCEG Institutional Nominee for NCI Pathway to Independence Award for Outstanding Early Stage Postdoctoral Researchers (K99/R00) [about "Early K99" Grant - NIH] | [about "Early K99" Grant - Stanford Medicine] | [Notice of Funding Opportunity Number: PAR-23-286]
	NIH Fellows Award for Research Excellence (FARE) 2026 (top 25% of all applicants) [List of FARE 2026 Awardees Abstracts] | [about FARE]
	NIH Outstanding Graduate Research
2023 & 2024	Women in Statistics and Data Science Conference Student Travel Award (twice)
2023	UMD Jacob K. Goldhaber Travel Grant
	UMD International Conference Student Support Award
2022 & 2023	UMD Graduate Student Travel Fellowship (twice)
2022	Rutgers University Travel Award for Conference on Advances in Bayesian and Frequentist Statistics
2021 - 2024	UMD Tuition Award for External Fellowship (4 times)
	NIH Predoctoral Fellowship (4 times) [about NIH Graduate Partnerships Program (GPP)]
2019 & 2020	UMD Dean's Fellowship (twice)
2017	First Award in Thesis Contest on Deep Integration of Key Competence and Classroom Teaching (NO.1 Middle School Affiliated to Central China Normal University)
2016	USTC Outstanding Graduate
2014 & 2015	USTC First Award of Academic Scholarship (twice)
2014	NNU Outstanding Graduate
	NNU First Award of Feng Ruer Scholarship
	NNU Outstanding Dissertation
2013	Certificate of Recommendation for Exemption from Entrance Examination—USTC Graduate Program
	Eligibility for Recommended Admission (top 5% in Mathematics Teacher Education Program, NNU)
	Second Award of Jiangsu Teaching Professional Skills Contest (ranked 4th in Mathematics across the Jiangsu Province)
2012	NNU Second Award in Mathematical Modeling Contest

Honors (continued)

- NNU Outstanding Debate Team Award, Debate Competition on "Is Beauty Subjective or Objective?" Member of the award-winning team arguing that beauty is objective.

2010 & 2011 — NNU First Award of Rolling Scholarship (twice)

2009 — NNU First Award in Computer Contest

Academic Activities

Invited Presentations

2026
- International Biometric Conference (IBC), Seoul, South Korea
- STATGEN 2026: Conference on Statistics in Genomics and Genetics, Emory University, Atlanta, Georgia, USA
- Biostatistics Branch of NCI-DCEG Works in Progress, Rockville, Maryland, USA

2024
- Women in Statistics and Data Science (WSDS), Reston, Virginia, USA

Contributed Presentations

2026
- The American Society of Human Genetics (ASHG) Annual Meeting, Montreal, Canada
- Joint Statistical Meetings (JSM), Boston, Massachusetts, USA
- The 11th Workshop on Biostatistics and Bioinformatics, Georgia State University, Atlanta, Georgia, USA (Contributed Poster as a recipient of the IMS New Researchers Travel Award and NSF Travel Support Award)

2025
- Joint Statistical Meetings (JSM), Nashville, Tennessee, USA
- The 17th Annual NCI-DCEG Fellows' Training Symposium, Rockville, Maryland, USA

2024
- Joint Statistical Meetings (JSM), Portland, Oregon, USA
- AI Day for Federal Statistics, National Academy of Sciences, Washington DC, USA
- Probability and Statistics Day, University of Maryland, Baltimore County (UMBC), Baltimore, Maryland, USA
- NIH Annual Graduate Student Research Symposium, Bethesda, Maryland, USA

2023
- Women in Statistics and Data Science (WSDS), Seattle, Washington, USA
- Joint Statistical Meetings (JSM), Toronto, Canada
- Probability and Statistics Day, University of Maryland, Baltimore County (UMBC), Baltimore, Maryland, USA

2022
- Conference on Advances in Bayesian and Frequentist Statistics with a Celebration of the 80th Birthday of Professor William E. Strawderman, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey, USA
- Annual Conference on Quantitative Approaches in Biology, Northwestern University, Chicago, Ohio, USA

Attendant

2026
- Artificial Intelligence (AI) Expo, The Department of Health and Human Services (HHS), Washington D.C., USA
- NIH Library Artificial Intelligence (AI) Trainings led by OpenAI experts, Bethesda, Maryland, USA
- Biostatistics Symposium of South California (BSSC), Newport Beach, California, USA

Academic Activities (continued)

2025 — Eastern North American Region (ENAR), New Orleans, Louisiana, USA

2024 — Statistics in the Age of AI Conference, The George Washington University (GWU), Washington DC, USA

— Eastern North American Region (ENAR), Baltimore, Maryland, USA

2023 — National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI) Biostatistics Workshop on Clinical Trial Designs: Innovative Endpoints and Futility Monitoring, Bethesda, Maryland, USA

2022 — International Small Area Estimation (SAE) Annual Conference, UMD, College Park, Maryland, USA

2016 — National Tianyuan Foundation Summer School on Pure Mathematics, Summer Seminar on Pure Mathematics, Zhejiang University, Hangzhou, China

2013 — Yangtze River Delta Symposium on Partial Differential Equations and Doctoral Student Forum, Tongji University, Shanghai, China

Grant Writing Workshop

2026 — NCI K Grant Writing Workshop, Bethesda, Maryland, USA

— NCI-DCEG Writing Your Specific Aims Session, Rockville, Maryland, USA

2025 — NCI-DCEG Grant Writing Workshop, Rockville, Maryland, USA

Software

R Packages and Research Code

- **Heritability-Velocity** — Author and Maintainer. Reproducible framework for joint estimation of static and dynamic heritability components in longitudinal phenotypes, featuring scalable AI-REML and REHE algorithms for genome-wide data. [GitHub] | [arXiv]

- **PLCO** — Author and Maintainer. Mixed-effects modeling framework with crossed genetic and individual-specific random effects to quantify genetic influences on PSA trajectories in large-scale prostate cancer screening studies. [GitHub] | [Paper]

- **AARP** — Author and Maintainer. Implementation of measurement error models for bias correction in food frequency questionnaire–based dietary intake assessment. [GitHub] | [Paper]

Programming and Statistical Computing

- R | Python | C/C++ | SQL | Jupyter Notebook

Research Infrastructure

- NIH Biowulf High-Performance Computing Cluster | All of Us Research Hub | UK Biobank

Scientific Writing and Reproducibility

- LaTeX | Microsoft Word | R Markdown | Git

Teaching

Teaching Assistant / Grader

Fall 2019 — **Sampling Theory (STAT440)**, Undergraduate/master-level.
Grader, UMD

Spring 2020 — **Introduction to Linear Algebra (MATH240)**, Undergraduate-level.
Teaching Assistant, UMD

Summer 2020 — **Introduction to Mathematical Proof (MATH310)**, Undergraduate-level.
Grader, UMD

Introduction to Probability Theory (STAT410), Undergraduate/master-level.
Grader, UMD

Fall 2020 & Spring 2021 — **Elementary Probability and Statistics (STAT100)**, Undergraduate-level.
Teaching Assistant, UMD

Spring 2015 & 2016 — **Calculus II**, Undergraduate-level.
Teaching Assistant, USTC

Fall 2016 — **Calculus I**, Undergraduate-level.
Teaching Assistant, USTC

Mathematics Teacher (Internship)

2013/09 - 2013/11 — **High School Mathematics**. High school level.
Mathematics Teacher Intern, Jinling High School, Nanjing, China

Service

Journal Reviewer

2021 - present — Biometrics (1); Statistics in Medicine (2); Journal of Biopharmaceutical Statistics (1); Frontiers in Oncology (1); LabMed Discovery (1)

Judging

2026 — Chief Judge, NIH Fellows Award for Research Excellence (FARE) 2027 Competition

Conference / Seminar Organizer

2024 — Co-organizer of the panel "Discussion of Mentoring Program and Participant Experiences" at WSDS 2024

Chair of the session "Rethinking Current Modeling Strategies: Advances and Applications" at JSM 2024

2023 — Chair of the session "Concurrent - Statistical Insights into Mortality and Inference: From Choquet Capacities to Demographic Patterns" at WSDS 2023

Mentoring

2025–present — Co-mentor (with **Paul S. Albert, PhD**) of postbaccalaureate fellow **Sumaja Bandreddi** (M.S., B.A., University of Virginia), Biostatistics Branch, DCEG, NCI, NIH

Spring 2021 — Directed Reading Program mentor for undergraduate **Andrew Craun**, Department of Mathematics, University of Maryland, College Park

Service (continued)

Leadership

2026	Member, NIH Fellows Award for Research Excellence (FARE) 2027 Committee
2022–2023	Vice President, Women in Mathematics, University of Maryland, College Park
2020–2021	Representative, Graduate Student Government, University of Maryland, College Park
2010–2011	Team Leader, Volunteer Interpreters Group, Nanjing Yunjin Museum, Nanjing, China

Volunteer Service

2026	Volunteer, The Chinese Biopharmaceutical Association-USA (CBA)
2025	Volunteer, Sino-American Pharmaceutical Professionals Association (SAPA)-DC
2022	Volunteer Interviewee, The Center for Mathematics Education, University of Maryland, College Park
2009–2010	Volunteer Teacher, Nanjing Hongshan Primary School for Children of Migrant Workers, Nanjing, China

Memberships

2026 - present	American Society of Human Genetics
2024 - present	Washington Statistical Society
	International Chinese Statistical Association
	Section of Statistics in Genetics and Genomics
2023 - present	American Statistical Association
	Institute of Mathematical Statistics
	Society for Mathematical Biology
	Caucus for Women in Statistics and Data Science
	Eastern North America Region/International Biometric Society
2019 - 2025	American Mathematical Society

References

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Jianxin Shi
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Doron Levy
Professor of Mathematics
Chair, Department of Mathematics
Director, Brin Mathematics Research Center
Co-director, the NCI-UMD Partnership for Integrative Cancer Research
Fellow of the Society for Industrial and Applied Mathematics (SIAM)
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